

Vendor Screening Rubric

Bronte Harbour Classic 5K - Application Review System

Purpose: Standardized scoring system to evaluate vendor applications and ensure quality, brand fit, and category balance.

Screening Process Overview

Review Timeline

- **Application Received:** Date application submitted
- **Initial Review:** Within 2 business days (exclusion check)
- **Detailed Review:** Within 5 business days (full scoring)
- **Decision:** Within 7 business days (approval/rejection/waitlist)
- **Notification:** Same day as decision

Review Team

- **Primary Reviewer:** Vendor Expo Coordinator
- **Secondary Reviewer:** Project Manager (for borderline cases)
- **Final Approval:** Race Director (for high-value or controversial vendors)

Screening Criteria

Criterion 1: Exclusion Check (PASS/FAIL)

Automatic Rejection if vendor falls into any exclusion category:

- ■ Cannabis/Marijuana products
- ■ Tobacco/Vaping products
- ■ MLM/Pyramid schemes (unless clearly product-focused and professional)
- ■ Political organizations
- ■ Religious organizations (proselytizing)
- ■ Adult-only products/services
- ■ Direct competitor to confirmed sponsor
- ■ Business with poor reputation (negative reviews, BBB issues)

Action: If FAIL, reject immediately with polite explanation. If PASS, continue to scoring.

Criterion 2: Geography Score (0-3 points)

Scoring:

- **3 points:** Oakville/Bronte (immediate event area)
- **2 points:** Halton Region (Burlington, Milton, Halton Hills)
- **1 point:** GTA West/Central (Mississauga, Hamilton, Etobicoke, Brampton)
- **0 points:** Broader GTA or beyond

Rationale: Local businesses have stronger community connection and higher likelihood of participation.

Criterion 3: Brand Fit Score (0-3 points)

Scoring:

- **3 points:** Perfect alignment
- Running/fitness stores, athletic gear
- Family services, kids activities
- Local food vendors (healthy options)
- Community organizations
- **2 points:** Good alignment
- Wellness services, lifestyle products
- Local retail (boutiques, artisan crafts)
- Professional services with community focus
- **1 point:** Acceptable alignment
- General retail, professional services
- Technology with fitness/health angle
- **0 points:** Poor alignment
- Unrelated to event theme
- Corporate/impersonal feel
- No clear connection to active lifestyle or families

Rationale: Vendors should align with event values and participant interests.

Criterion 4: Visual/Professional Score (0-2 points)

Scoring:

- **2 points:** Strong visual presence
- Professional website/social media
- High-quality product photos
- Previous event experience with photos
- Clear brand identity
- **1 point:** Adequate presentation
- Basic website or social media
- Some product images
- Limited event experience
- **0 points:** Unclear presentation
- No online presence

- Poor quality images
- No event experience
- Unprofessional appearance

Rationale: Professional presentation indicates quality vendor experience for participants.

Criterion 5: Uniqueness Score (0-2 points)

Scoring:

- **2 points:** Unique category or offering
- First vendor in this category
- Unique product/service not yet represented
- Fills gap in vendor mix
- **1 point:** Some differentiation
- Similar to existing vendors but with unique angle
- Different target market or approach
- **0 points:** Duplicate
- Multiple similar vendors already confirmed
- No differentiation from existing mix
- Category already well-represented

Rationale: Maintain diverse vendor mix, avoid too many similar vendors.

Criterion 6: Category Balance (Bonus/Deduction)

Scoring:

- **+1 point:** Fills gap in underrepresented category
- **0 points:** Category at target level
- **-1 point:** Category already overrepresented (if at cap)

Rationale: Ensure balanced vendor mix across all categories.

Criterion 7: Insurance & Compliance (PASS/FAIL)

Requirements:

- ■ Valid business insurance (proof provided)
- ■ Insurance valid through event date (June 21, 2026)
- ■ Food permits (if food vendor)
- ■ Professional business registration

Action: If FAIL, request missing documentation before approval. If PASS, continue.

Total Score Calculation

Base Score (Maximum: 10 points)

- Geography: 0-3 points
- Brand Fit: 0-3 points
- Visual/Professional: 0-2 points
- Uniqueness: 0-2 points

Bonus/Deduction

- Category Balance: -1 to +1 point

Final Score Range: 0-11 points

Approval Decision Matrix

Tier 1: Immediate Approval (8-11 points)

- **Action:** Approve immediately
- **Payment Link:** Send within 24 hours
- **Priority:** High priority for booth assignment
- **Notes:** Ideal vendors, fast-track process

Tier 2: Standard Approval (6-7 points)

- **Action:** Approve if category balance allows
- **Payment Link:** Send within 48 hours
- **Priority:** Standard booth assignment
- **Notes:** Good vendors, normal process

Tier 3: Conditional Approval (4-5 points)

- **Action:** Approve only if needed to reach 50+ target
- **Payment Link:** Send if approved
- **Priority:** Standard or lower-traffic booth
- **Notes:** Acceptable vendors, fill gaps if needed

Tier 4: Rejection (0-3 points)

- **Action:** Reject with explanation

- **Communication:** Polite rejection email
- **Notes:** Keep goodwill for future years
- **Documentation:** Record reason for future reference

Special Cases: Waitlist

- **Action:** Waitlist if category at cap but vendor is high quality
- **Notification:** Explain waitlist status, timeline
- **Priority:** First to approve if space opens
- **Notes:** Maintain relationship, may approve later

Category-Specific Considerations

Health, Fitness & Running

- **Priority:** High (target 8-12 vendors)
- **Special Notes:** Prefer local running stores, avoid direct sponsor competitors
- **Scoring Adjustment:** +0.5 points for perfect category fit

Local Food & Beverage

- **Priority:** High (target 6-10 vendors)
- **Special Notes:** Must have proper permits, insurance, food handling certification
- **Scoring Adjustment:** Strict compliance check, reject if permits missing

Family Services & Activities

- **Priority:** High (target 6-8 vendors)
- **Special Notes:** Must be clearly family-friendly, appropriate for children
- **Scoring Adjustment:** +0.5 points for strong family focus

Wellness & Lifestyle

- **Priority:** Medium (target 5-8 vendors)
- **Special Notes:** Avoid controversial products, prefer established businesses
- **Scoring Adjustment:** Standard scoring

Local Retail & Services

- **Priority:** Medium (target 8-12 vendors)

- **Special Notes:** Prefer local businesses, avoid chain stores unless local franchise
- **Scoring Adjustment:** +0.5 points for local ownership

Community Organizations

- **Priority:** Medium (target 4-6 vendors)
- **Special Notes:** Non-profit rate may apply, verify 501(c) status if applicable
- **Scoring Adjustment:** +0.5 points for community impact

Professional Services

- **Priority:** Low (target 2-4 vendors)
- **Special Notes:** Must have community connection, avoid overly corporate
- **Scoring Adjustment:** Higher bar for approval, must be exceptional fit

Technology & Innovation

- **Priority:** Low (target 2-3 vendors)
- **Special Notes:** Must have fitness/health angle, avoid pure tech companies
- **Scoring Adjustment:** Higher bar for approval, must be relevant to event

Review Checklist

Initial Review (Exclusion Check)

- ☐ Check exclusion list (cannabis, tobacco, MLM, etc.)
- ☐ Verify not direct sponsor competitor
- ☐ Check business reputation (Google reviews, BBB)
- ☐ Confirm family-friendly nature

Detailed Review (Scoring)

- ☐ Score Geography (0-3)
- ☐ Score Brand Fit (0-3)
- ☐ Score Visual/Professional (0-2)
- ☐ Score Uniqueness (0-2)
- ☐ Check Category Balance (+1/-1)
- ☐ Calculate Total Score
- ☐ Verify Insurance & Compliance

Decision Making

- ☐ Determine approval tier based on score
- ☐ Check category balance (can we accept this category?)
- ☐ Review special requirements (power, space, etc.)
- ☐ Make final decision (Approve/Reject/Waitlist)

Documentation

- ☐ Record scores in CRM
- ☐ Add review notes
- ☐ Document decision rationale
- ☐ Update category balance tracker

Communication

- ☐ Send approval/rejection/waitlist email
- ☐ Include payment link if approved
- ☐ Set payment deadline (14 days)
- ☐ Update CRM with status

Approval Workflow

Step 1: Application Received

- Auto-acknowledge to applicant
- Add to CRM "Application Details" sheet
- Assign to reviewer

Step 2: Initial Review (Day 1-2)

- Exclusion check
- If FAIL: Reject immediately
- If PASS: Move to detailed review

Step 3: Detailed Review (Day 3-5)

- Score all criteria
- Calculate total score

- Check category balance
- Make preliminary decision

Step 4: Final Decision (Day 6-7)

- Review borderline cases with team
- Confirm category balance allows approval
- Make final decision

Step 5: Notification (Day 7)

- Send approval/rejection/waitlist email
- Update CRM status
- Set payment deadline if approved

Step 6: Payment Processing

- Monitor payment status
- Send reminders if overdue
- Confirm booth assignment upon payment

Quality Assurance

Review Consistency

- **Scoring Calibration:** Reviewers should score sample applications together to ensure consistency
- **Regular Review:** Weekly review of approval decisions to ensure quality
- **Feedback Loop:** Track vendor performance post-event to validate scoring accuracy

Continuous Improvement

- **Score Validation:** Compare pre-event scores to post-event vendor ratings
- **Category Adjustments:** Adjust category targets based on application quality
- **Process Refinement:** Update rubric based on learnings from Year 1

Notes

- **Be Fair:** Consistent scoring across all applications

- **Be Flexible:** Consider special circumstances, but maintain standards
- **Be Transparent:** Clear communication about decisions (when appropriate)
- **Be Efficient:** Streamline process to avoid delays
- **Be Professional:** Maintain positive relationships even when rejecting

Document Version: 1.0

Last Updated: December 2025

Next Review: After first 20 applications reviewed